

Seat of Enlightenment

Located in the small, religious town of Bodh Gaya, the new IIM is fast emerging as a major B-school defying all odds

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A VAST TRACT OF land filled with shrubs and the occasional centuries-old tree. Two four-storied dilapidated hostel buildings occupied by former students of Magadh University, and one building with two and a half rooms, in equally poor condition. This was the scene that greeted Vinita S. Sahay when she took charge of the newly-founded Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Bodh Gaya in February 2018.

Inaugurated in August 2015, the B-school had been mentored by the premier IIM Calcutta for nearly two and a half years following its inception. But there were teething issues. No full-time director. No senior administrative staff. No permanent faculty. Plus, a joust with occupants of two hostels belonging to Magadh University, who refused to move despite the 118-acre land having been transferred to the institute. By the time Sahay took over, and when it became an institute in its own right, the first batch of MBA students (2015-17) had already graduated.

Giant in the Making

IIM Bodh Gaya has broken into the Top 50 list on debut

NAME OF THE INSTITUTE
IIM Bodh Gaya

LOCATION
Bodh Gaya, Bihar

CAMPUS
Spread across 118 acres, with 75 acres of reserve land

RANK
46

SCORE
681.1/1,000

PLACEMENT PERFORMANCE
176.1/250

PLACEMENT RANK
28

Much has changed since those difficult initial days—the old campus building has been renovated to house administrative departments and temporary classrooms (the permanent ones are still being built), a sprawling new academic building, a sports complex, students' hostels and faculty quarters, all in keeping with the ethos of the land where the Buddha attained enlightenment (more on that later). And yes, it has taken possession of the two hostels. "There were multiple other issues. We had a very, very tough time," Sahay now recalls with a smile, revealing a sense of collective achievement. At times, the institute had to rely on the local administration for help, which included calling in the police to assist it in taking over the buildings.

Overcoming these initial barriers proved crucial for the fledgeling institute. Starting with less than 40 students per batch under its regular full-time MBA programme, it now has nearly 300 students for the 2023-25 session. It managed to place all its students in the 2016-18 batch and since then the number of job offers and size of packages have swelled. Over the past four